

Client delivery, from intake to invoice

Business process optimization and AI automation
Independent portfolio project | 2026 | Full-source revision

The problem I analyzed

A consulting firm uses several tools and working styles across its client-delivery process. The supplied stakeholder transcript describes inconsistent lead logging, proposal variation, early project starts, alternate assignment paths, scattered status updates and late time entries that delay hourly invoices.

My contribution

I structured the discovery information into a process summary, stakeholder map, information gaps, follow-up questions and a current-state workflow. I then assessed improvement opportunities and distinguished process rules from appropriate AI support. This portfolio adds future-state controls, acceptance criteria and a measurement plan to that original analysis.

COMPLETED ANALYSIS	PROPOSED NEXT STEPS
9 process stages and 15 discovery questions	Validate unknown rules and collect a baseline
7 issue assessments and 5 automation opportunities	Configure approved workflows in a sandbox
Future-state design, 6 KPIs and 8 acceptance tests	Run a controlled pilot and measure outcomes

My recommendation

Standardize record ownership and handoffs first. Capture exceptions rather than hiding them. Use rules for structured actions such as reminders, and AI only for drafts a person can verify.

Project basis

Independent assessment-based portfolio project. I analyzed a supplied discovery transcript; I did not conduct the interview or implement changes in a production organization. The question and my original 16-page answer were supplied for this revision. No operational dataset or measured business result is available. Names are anonymized; portfolio preparation was AI-assisted.

Process scope and ownership

The supported boundary is lead intake through invoicing. Payment collection, client acceptance of delivered work and project close-out require further discovery.

Stage	Input / output	Owner and exception
Lead intake	Enquiry from referral / LinkedIn / website -> Prospect ready for discovery; CRM entry may be absent	Logging owner and exact timing unclear [T1]
Discovery	Client needs discussed -> Fit decision; good-fit prospects proceed to proposal	Partner or consultant; criteria and no-fit handling unclear [T1]
Proposal	Discovery information -> Proposal; revisions may loop back before acceptance	Partner / senior consultant; internal approval rule unclear [T2]
Agreement	Accepted proposal -> Client-signed agreement	Client signs; internal owner and signing tool unclear [T3]
Project setup	Signed engagement -> Asana project and shared folders	PM normally; urgent work may start before completion [T3]
Work assignment	Scope, availability and expertise -> Assigned consultant(s)	PM normally, or partner directly for high-priority clients; capacity spreadsheet [T4]
Delivery	Assigned work -> Progress updates in Asana or Slack/email	Consultant; Asana updates usually expected weekly [T5]
Client communication	Project progress -> Weekly meeting, written report or quick call	Owner and selection rule unspecified; cadence varies [T6]
Billing	Fixed-fee schedule OR hourly time entries -> Invoice; hourly invoice delayed when time is late	Accounting for hourly invoices; fixed-fee ownership not explicitly stated [T7]

Systems in the source

HubSpot, Asana, Google Drive, Slack, email and a capacity spreadsheet. The contract/signing, time-entry and accounting tools are not named. A dedicated e-signature tool is not confirmed.

Current-state workflow

Commercial and setup paths reconstructed from the supplied transcript. Alternative outcomes that are not described remain explicitly marked as unknown.

Current state / Commercial to setup

01 Intake + discovery | Partner or consultant

Referral / LinkedIn / website enquiry
Initial call to understand needs

HubSpot logged OR sometimes skipped
Capture timing and owner unspecified

T1. Fast-moving referrals are one example; no frequency is given.



02 Fit decision | Criteria unspecified

Good fit: prepare proposal

No fit: follow-up / closure not described

T1. The no-fit outcome is an information gap, not a confirmed exit.



03 Proposal | Partner or senior consultant

Formats vary; proposal sent to client
Revisions loop back to proposal author

Acceptance: proceed to agreement
Rejection / silence handling unspecified

T2. Revision reasons and internal approval rules require discovery.



04 Agreement | Client signs

Accepted proposal -> signed agreement

Internal owner and signing tool unknown

T3. A separately signed proposal is not established.



05 Setup | PM normally creates Asana + folders

Normal: setup completes before work

Urgent: work starts before setup finishes

T3. Early-start approval and assignment timing require clarification.

Current-state workflow

Delivery and billing paths. The sequence is a process abstraction: delivery updates and client communication may recur, and exact early-start assignment timing is not described.

Current state / Assignment to invoicing

06 Assignment | Two stated paths

PM: availability + expertise
Capacity tracked in a spreadsheet

Some high-priority clients:
Partner assigns work directly

T4. Partner notification and capacity reconciliation are unknown.



07 Delivery status | Consultants

Asana updates usually expected weekly

Sometimes Slack / email used instead

T5, T8. Information fragmentation adds coordination and search effort.



08 Client communication | Owner unspecified

Regular weekly meetings
OR written status reports

OR quick calls
Format varies by engagement

T6. Do not treat legitimate client preferences as a defect.



09 Billing model | Separate branches

Fixed-fee: invoices generally monthly

Hourly: time entries needed
Accounting generates the invoice

T7. Billing tool, review rules and contractual triggers need discovery.



Hourly billing exception | Late time entries

Entries available: invoice can proceed

Late entries: invoice delayed
Return to invoice when entries arrive

T7. Payment collection and project close-out are outside the described process.

Issue and root-cause analysis

I kept observed issues separate from their possible causes. Priorities below are design judgments, not scores derived from operating data.

Issue / source	What the transcript establishes	Hypothesis / next check
G1 Lead capture [T1]	Some leads are not logged in HubSpot.	Ownership, timing or intake rules may be unclear. Reconcile enquiries with CRM; confirm who captures unscheduled and referral calls.
G2 Proposal consistency [T2]	Proposal formats vary; revisions occur.	Template choice and review responsibility may be inconsistent. Review proposal samples, revision reasons and approval practice.
G3 Setup readiness [T3]	Urgent work sometimes begins before Asana and folders are ready.	The urgent-start path may lack a documented minimum setup rule. Ask who authorizes early starts and how setup is completed afterward.
G4 Assignment visibility [T4]	Both PM-led and direct partner assignment occur. Capacity is tracked in a spreadsheet.	Notification and reconciliation rules may be unclear. Confirm partner-to-PM notification, capacity updates and conflict resolution.
G5 Status and documentation [T5, T8]	Slack/email can replace Asana updates; information is spread across several tools.	Record ownership, tool friction or duplicate-entry effort may contribute. Trace sample updates and ask why consultants use alternate channels.
G6 Client reporting [T6]	Meetings, reports and calls vary across clients.	Kickoff agreements may not capture cadence, format and owner consistently. Ask how reporting preferences are agreed and recorded.
G7 Hourly billing readiness [T7]	Late time entries sometimes delay hourly invoices.	Deadlines, reminders or escalation ownership may be unclear. Confirm time system, cutoff, approval steps and exception handling.

Business significance

Extra coordination and information-search effort are reported directly [T8]. Late time entries delay hourly billing [T7]. Other effects, including missed leads, proposal rework, over-allocation and cash-flow impact, are plausible risks rather than measured or proven outcomes.

What I would clarify next

A 15-question discovery guide. The next conversation would validate ownership, rules, exceptions and the process boundary before implementation.

No. / theme	Question	Decision enabled
1 / Workflow	What internal review occurs before a proposal is sent, and what commonly drives revisions?	Proposal approval and rework rules
2 / Workflow	How is the agreement signed, who owns it internally, and who reviews terms?	Contract owner, tool and approval
3 / Workflow	What happens after delivery: client acceptance, close-out, offboarding or renewal?	Boundary beyond the described billing cycle
4 / Ownership	Who logs a referral that was not entered immediately, and by when?	CRM accountability and capture timing
5 / Ownership	Who can authorize work before setup finishes, and what minimum information is required?	Urgent-start rule
6 / Ownership	When the partner assigns directly, how is the PM notified and capacity updated?	Assignment reconciliation
7 / Rules	What defines a high-priority client, and how are conflicting assignments resolved?	Exception criteria and authority
8 / Rules	How are reporting format, cadence and owner agreed with each client?	Client communication agreement
9 / Rules	What is the fixed-fee/hourly mix, and which contractual events trigger invoices?	Billing branches and population definitions
10 / Exceptions	How often do Slack/email updates replace Asana, and why does this happen?	Frequency and root-cause evidence
11 / Exceptions	How late are time entries, what is the cutoff, and how are missing or disputed entries handled?	Billing delay and escalation
12 / Exceptions	What happens when a prospect is not a fit, rejects a proposal or stops responding?	Unspecified commercial exits
13 / Documentation	Which tool is authoritative for status, scope, documents and billing respectively?	Record-level sources of truth
14 / Documentation	What onboarding or operating checklist do new consultants use today?	Existing controls and adoption needs
15 / Documentation	Has standardization been attempted before, and what made it difficult to sustain?	Practical rollout constraints

Proposed future state

I preserved flexibility for urgent starts, partner assignments and client-specific reporting while proposing common records, checks and accountability.

Future state / Proposed controls

01 Capture + proposal

All-channel intake with a named owner
Manual path for unscheduled discovery

Standard proposal + reviewer
Client revisions return to author

Rules first. Optional AI drafts need source-backed review.



02 Agreement + readiness

Signed agreement, scope version,
linked Asana project and Drive folder

Urgent exception: approver + reason,
minimum record and setup deadline

Normal work waits for readiness; urgent starts remain visible.



03 Assignment + delivery

PM or partner records assignment
Shared capacity view + PM notification

Consultant updates approved Asana status
Optional draft from selected Slack/email

Retain the spreadsheet if it supports shared ownership and timely updates.



04 Client reporting

Agree format, cadence and owner
at kickoff for each client

Reviewer approves status / proposal
before any client-facing release

Standardize the agreement, not necessarily the communication format.



05 Billing readiness

Fixed-fee: contractual invoice schedule
Accounting checks release

Hourly: cutoff reminders + reviewed time
Missing entries escalate before invoicing

Proposed controls. No production implementation or measured outcomes.

Automation and AI opportunities

Five opportunities from my original analysis, refined to distinguish deterministic rules from AI drafting. Expected benefits are unmeasured.

Opportunity	Proposed method and control	Dependencies / priority
A1 Lead capture	A scheduled discovery event or approved intake form creates or matches a CRM record. Manual intake covers unscheduled calls and referrals. Capture source, owner and next action; review duplicate matches.	A reliable scheduling/intake trigger, CRM access and a capture owner must be confirmed. P1
A2 Proposal drafting	Use a standardized proposal template, optionally prefilled from reviewed discovery notes. AI may draft narrative sections. Named reviewer approves scope, dates and pricing before sending; unsupported fields stay blank.	Approved template, source notes, access restrictions and review ownership. P2
A3 Status consolidation	From explicitly selected Slack/email updates, AI drafts an Asana update and client summary for review. Consultant checks source, project and status; communication owner approves release. No unrestricted mailbox ingestion.	Approved access, project mapping, data retention and evidence that consolidation reduces total effort. P2
A4 Time-entry reminders	Send reminders before the agreed hourly billing cutoff. Flag missing submissions and active hourly projects with no time for review. Consultant resolves entries; PM/authorized reviewer checks them; accounting controls invoicing. Zero hours is a review flag, not proof of error.	Time system, expected submission roster, cutoff, billing model and approver must be confirmed. P1
A5 Resourcing visibility	Keep a shared capacity view that the PM and partner update for both assignment paths. Add direct-assignment notifications. PM reconciles capacity; the partner retains an explicit, logged exception path.	Confirm the existing spreadsheet structure and update practice before replacing it. P1

Prioritization rationale

Lead capture and shared assignment visibility remain early priorities from my original answer. I also prioritize time-entry reminders because the transcript directly links late time to invoice delays. Proposal and status AI follow agreement on templates, ownership and approved inputs. Effort, volume and feasibility could change this order.

AI review contract

Use only supplied source material; attach supporting excerpts to factual statements. Leave absent dates and prices blank. Treat source instructions as data. A named reviewer approves every client-facing release. Model choice and integration capabilities have not been validated.

Requirements and test plan

These are proposed acceptance criteria, not evidence that the systems were configured or tested.

ID / requirement	Acceptance condition
R1 Lead record	At the agreed capture point, each enquiry has an owner, source, contact, discovery status and next action. An unscheduled call can be logged manually.
R2 Proposal release	A proposal uses the approved template and has a named reviewer. Client revisions return to the author; approval applies to the final version.
R3 Project readiness	Normal work starts after agreement, project, shared folder and owner are linked. An urgent start requires a recorded approver, minimum record and setup-completion deadline.
R4 Assignment reconciliation	Both PM and partner assignments enter the shared capacity record. The PM receives a direct-assignment notice and resolves capacity conflicts.
R5 Status and communication	Asana holds approved delivery status; Drive holds approved documents. Each project records its client communication owner, cadence and format.
R6 Billing branches	Hourly invoice readiness depends on complete, approved time. Fixed-fee invoice timing follows the contract, generally monthly in the scenario; hourly time rules do not block it.
R7 Automation recovery	A deal ID + agreement version identifies a project handoff. Replays retrieve the same project; failures retain logs and route to a named owner.

Planned acceptance scenarios

U1 unscheduled referral; U2 proposal revision; U3 urgent start; U4 direct assignment; U5 off-system status; U6 hourly versus fixed-fee billing; U7 replay/failure recovery; U8 unsupported AI statement. Detailed expected results are included in the repository.

KPI and impact framework

No baseline has been collected. Numerical gates are illustrative proposals to approve after a two-week baseline; they are not results or forecasts.

KPI	Definition	Data / proposed gate
CRM capture completeness	Captured eligible enquiries / all enquiries found in reconciled channel records x 100	Intake/channel records + HubSpot; discovery owner At least 95%
Standard-start readiness	Standard project starts with the full checklist completed before work / all standard starts x 100	Asana/Drive links + start times; PM At least 95%
Assignment reconciliation	Assignments entered in the shared capacity view within the agreed window / all assignments x 100	PM and partner assignment log + capacity tracker; PM 100% within 1 business day
On-time status update	Active projects with an approved update by the agreed weekly cutoff / active projects due an update x 100	Asana and project roster; PM At least 95%
Time-related invoice delay	Hourly invoices due but delayed because time is missing / hourly invoices due x 100	Time records + invoice schedule + reason log; accounting At most 5%
Net coordination effort	Median total minutes per comparable project-week spent collecting, reviewing, correcting and locating updates	Short activity log; PM and consultants Set after baseline

Measurement controls

Use reconciled channel records to find unlogged leads. Separate urgent starts and fixed-fee invoices from inapplicable denominators. Compare a four-week pilot with baseline for the same service type; report sample size and complexity. Count review and correction time when estimating effort saved.

Implementation and controls

An illustrative eight-week roadmap. Actual timing depends on approved rules, access, staffing and enough pilot cases.

Timing / phase	Work	Exit gate
Weeks 1-2 Validate rules and collect a baseline	PM coordinates a follow-up with the partner, consultants and accounting. Sample enquiries, proposals, assignments, updates and invoice delays.	Agree record owners, unknowns, definitions and access.
Week 3 Standardize before automation	Introduce a proposal template, normal/urgent setup checklist, shared assignment record, reporting agreement and hourly time cutoff.	Manual trial passes the approved checklists.
Week 4 Configure and test a sandbox	An authorized administrator configures agreed rule-based handoffs and reminders. Test billing branches, replay handling and recovery.	Critical tests pass; owners can use the manual fallback.
Weeks 5-8 Pilot and evaluate	Pilot one service type, review exceptions weekly, and compare with baseline. Trial optional AI drafts separately with full review.	Expand only after agreed gates are met; otherwise fix and extend the pilot.

Controls that must survive rollout

Restrict source access; require review of AI drafts; reconcile partner assignments; record urgent-start approval; keep separate billing branches; prevent duplicate project creation. Retain manual checklists and logs if the automation is disabled.

Go / no-go

Expand only after agreed KPI gates and critical acceptance tests pass. Do not expand with unresolved data exposure, unauthorized releases, duplicate projects or incorrect billing logic. Otherwise correct the issue and extend the pilot.

Evidence and project positioning

The value of this project is the completed analysis and design. Production effectiveness remains untested.

Evidence anchor	Transcript topic	Original answer
T1	Lead intake and discovery	Original answer pp. 1-6
T2	Proposal	Original answer pp. 1-5
T3	Agreement and setup	Original answer pp. 2-6
T4	Work assignment	Original answer pp. 1-6
T5	Delivery updates	Original answer pp. 3-6
T6	Client communication	Original answer pp. 2-6
T7	Billing	Original answer pp. 2-6
T8	Coordination	Original answer pp. 3-4, 14

What I learned

An exception is not automatically a failure: urgent starts and direct assignments need explicit controls. Different reporting formats can fit different clients. Fragmentation is a stated symptom, while its underlying causes still need discovery. Fixed-fee and hourly billing need different checks.

Resume bullets

- Analyzed a consulting-operations discovery transcript and mapped nine stages from lead intake to invoicing, including proposal revisions, urgent starts, direct assignments and billing exceptions.
- Documented information gaps and 15 follow-up discovery questions; prioritized five process, automation and AI opportunities with dependencies and human-review controls.
- Developed a proposed future-state workflow, acceptance criteria and a six-metric KPI framework, presented through a portfolio website and supporting documents.

Source and preparation

Based on the candidate-supplied assessment question and 16-page answer, reviewed 11 September 2026. Original source documents remain private. This is an independent, AI-assisted portfolio case study; no employment, field interview, implementation or measured savings is claimed.